



MOUNTAIN BIKING HIMACHAL – THE CHOORDHAR SANCTUARY,
April 9th – 14th, 2009

“Apple orchards, Deodar (Himalayan cedar) forests, perennial streams and the towering Choordhar peak make the race special. Dotted by small Himalayan villages, offering an insight into mountain life, temples along the trail with the gods as audience, the riding is going to be a song with the winds blowing through the forests in the spring of 2009. Five days of fun, riding and outdoors, “Mountain Biking Himachal – The Choordhar Trails” is just the event for everyone who loves the mountains, the fresh air and of course your own bike. It is an escape from the mundane, exploring the wild frontiers of the Himalayan backcountry in all its grandeur and serenity. Guaranteed, or rather should we say, take it for granted, a great riding opportunity through some of the world’s best trails, uphill’s and adrenalizing downhill’s with the zing! And lots of camaraderie!

AN INTRODUCTION

The “Choordhar”, translates “*bangle of snow*” stands tall, as tall as 3647mts in the Shivalik ranges of the lower Himalayas. The highest peak of this range, boasts of commanding views from its top. To its south are the Sutlej plains, affording scintillating views of the Shimla hills, Solan Hills and Chail, to its north great views of Badrinath and the gangetic plains. The peak has much prominence and is seen from all major places in the Shivaliks, Solan, Chail, Shimla, Dehradun and Chakrata.

In Himachal Pradesh, at the base of Choordhar lies the apple country of Chopal, dominated by the Choordhar sanctuary. Rich in flora and fauna, the Choordhar sanctuary has an excellent network of forest trails that connects it to major places like Shimla, Solan, Chail, Chakrata etc. These forest paths have been in existence since the British left the area, and are leading from one old heritage Dak Bungalow (rest house) to another.

A mountain biker’s delight, come April 2009, The Choordhar sanctuary will play host to the mountain biking community from around the world to come and ride these meandering trails. “*Mountain Biking Himachal – The Choordhar Trails*” is an initiative of Himalayan Adventure Sports & Tourism Promotion Association (the organizers of the 5 year old HERCULES MOUNTAIN BIKING HIMACHAL stage race enduro) in association with Hercules bikes and Himachal Tourism, to promote the sport of mountain biking in the state and showcase to the mountain biking community from around the world the grandeur of Himalayan trails.



THE RACE

This is a five day race in the spring of 2009, precisely from APRIL 9th – 14th, and starts at a place called “SARAIN” at the base of the Choordhar Mountain. We would come to the details of how to reach there later, first a basic little about the things. Sarain would serve as our base camp for 5 days and everyday’s riding would commence from the camp and finish at the camp. It’s a total riding of 180kms in four days, well that looks less, however then we mentioned this is a completely trail riding event. We explore the four directions from the base camp and on one day we get to ride up the mountain as well, the king of the Shivaliks, i.e. The Choordhar. Take our word; you would be the first ones to do this ever. The race would run in a timed stage format, 2 stages in a day, and one before lunch and one after lunch. Expect Nutrition halts along the way and a great atmosphere everyday. We don’t say it’s not tough, it’s not easy either. For most of its part it’s not a survival course. We would rather say it’s an unwinding race to welcome the Himalayan Springs.



THE ITINERARY

Thursday, April 9th, 2009.

Arrive in Shimla in the morning. Upon arrival, transfer to hotel. Refresh yourself and at 1300hrs board coach for onward journey to the base camp at Sarain (110kms-4hrs).

Friday, April 10th, 2009.

This is the first day of riding, as we meander through the forest trail towards “Pulwahal”. From Pulwahal it’s a second stage back to Sarain. Total riding distance 34kms.

Saturday, April 11th, 2009.

The second day of riding, as we navigate through the forest trail towards “Monalag”, and continue further towards “Deiya”. From “Deiya”, backtrack towards “Sarain”. Total riding distance 68kms.

Sunday, April 12th, 2009.

Sunday is fun day. Today we ride only for 27kms along the riverside trail to a place called “Dhawas” and back to Sarain.

Monday, April 13th, 2009.

As India celebrates the festival of “Baisakhi” and reaps the golden harvest, we sow the seeds for a first ever ride uphill to the “Choordhar top”. This is an uphill of 11 kms through a forest trail and a 2 kms hike to the top. After celebrating the fabulous views from the top, be cautious on the downhill back to Sarain.

Tuesday, April 14th, 2009.

After breakfast, board the coach back towards Shimla and we all reassemble at the hotel for the prize distribution ceremony.

WHO CAN ENTER

The event is open to all, though we have defined a few categories; Solo men, Solo women and Masters (age 40 and above). The minimum age of participation is 18 years as on the start of the adventure. Though anybody can take to the ride, we recommend a reasonable level of fitness and a sense of adventure to be able to ride the course.

HOW TO REACH

By Air: Shimla's airport is at a distance of 23 kilometers at Jubbarhatti. The Airport is well connected to Chandigarh, Kullu and Delhi. Kingfisher Airlines offer excellent services and connect Shimla to various parts of the country.

By Train: Shimla is connected to Kalka (96 kms) on Meter Gauge and it takes around 6 Hrs from KALKA to reach SHIMLA. There are 3-4 trains daily from Kalka to Shimla and vice-versa. Shivalik Express is luxury Deluxe Train on this route with less halts and pantry facility. One can also travel through Rail car (one of its kind mainly running only on this route in India). The overnight Kalka Mail from Delhi reaches Kalka in the early morning and that is the time to catch connecting trains on the splendid narrow-gauge link to Shimla. There are 103 tunnels on the route with longest being 1.2 K.M. long. The railway link was just awarded the heritage railway status in October 2008.

Time Table of Trains from Shimla to Kalka

Train No.	Departure Shimla	Arrival Kalka
2 KS	14:25	20:10
252 Dn	18:15	23:15
256 Dn	10:30	16:05
242 Dn	17:40	22:20

Time Table of Trains from Kalka to Shimla

Train No.	Departure Kalka	Arrival Shimla
1 KS	04:00	09:15
251 Up	06:00	11:00
255 Up	12:10	17:20
241 Up	05:30	10:15

By Road: Shimla is connected by road to all the major towns. The chart below shows the distance between the Major Towns and Shimla and duration of journey -

Location	Distance	Journey Time by Bus	Journey Time by LMV
Kalka	80 Kms	03:15 Hours	03:00 Hours
Chandigarh	119 Kms	04:00 Hours	03:30 Hours
Ambala	166 Kms	05:00 Hours	04:30 Hours
Delhi	370 Kms	09:00 Hours	08:00 Hours

ACCOMMODATION

The accommodation is at a centralized camp at Sarain, during the course of the race, in tents and on twin sharing basis. Upon arrival in Shimla, we get to refresh in a hotel and are thereafter transferred in a coach to the camps. There would be facilities to charge your mobiles and other gizmos at the camp.

CAMPING

There will be showers, toilets and water at the camps. All your equipment (Luggage & Bike Box) will be transported to the camps and be at your disposal. Luggage tags will be handed out prior to the start of the ride at the time of rider registration. We will stay in two men Alpine tents on Twin Sharing basis. There would be separate enclosures for Dining, sleeping, Bike park area etc.

BIKE SERVICE

Unfortunately, HASTPA is not being able to provide a service back up for the race. However you are welcome to bring along your experts (or depend upon it yourself). For your mechanic/expert one shall have to bear the same fees as your own.



ENTRY FEES

The entry fees per rider is Rs. 8,500/- for Indian riders and USD 250/- for riders with international passport. There is also an insurance charge, (risk insurance) covering the riders for any injuries sustained during the ride. For all riders it is mandatory to fill out an indemnity bond at the registration at the Pre-ride briefing on 09th April, 2009.

Supporters:

You are welcome to bring along your family and friends to "Mountain Biking Himachal – The Choordhar Trails". However where we shall be able to make arrangements for their stay in a similar fashion to yours, please specify for their details in the entry forms. The Entry fees per supporter Rs ADULT is 8,500/- and Children Rs 3,000/-

WHAT TO BRING

Bike: Mountain Biking Himachal – The Choordhar Trails shall run on village dirt roads, jeep tracks and single tracks in mountainous terrain. A front suspension, hard tail bike with 21 speeds Shimano Gear system is recommended. Riders who are keen on riding but have a problem in getting their bikes or novices who don't have a bike have the option of renting a similar bike from HASTPA @ of Rs. 3000/- for the duration of the event.

Clothes & Accessories: The Month of April is sunshine and cool breeze during the day in the surroundings of Choordhar sanctuary.. Expect day temperatures of about 15-20 degrees Celsius. Rain showers are not ruled out. Bring appropriate clothing. Light woollens are recommended. Also appropriate bike gear and accessories are recommended. Knee caps, Gloves, Riding shorts, Safety helmet, and Elbow guards are essential. A sunscreen lotion and your personal medication are necessary. Medical backup is available at the campsites and an ambulance will be traversing along the riders in case of any injuries caused during riding. A head lamp, tool kit, extra tubes, hand pump, Camelbak are all essential items which need to be carried in your day pack.

We also recommend:

- Hydration system
- Spare brake blocks / brake pads
- Spare gear cables
- Watch or other timing device
- Insect repellent !!!
- Zip Ties
- Chain oil
- Extra chain link
- Pocket camera
- Sun glasses
- Sun cream
- Lock (no secure bike storage available – every rider is responsible for his/her own bike)
- Chamois cream
- Money for possible repairs and massages
- Mobile phone battery charger

Requirements per Rider:

- Sufficient water / drink - roughly 750ml per hour – please bring a hydration system and bottles
- Adequate clothing for changeable conditions (i.e. waterproof jacket)
- Helmet – no helmet no ride
- Only one bike for the whole duration of the event
- Night lights for the night time trial with a minimum burn time of 1 _ hours
- Backup light for night time trail
- Money for eventual bike repairs, massages or for the odd snack you might fancy en-route

